

One Model, Forty Years: Lessons Learned and Scored Prescience from the FLORIDA System, 1986–2028

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Bottom line up front

In March 1989 a Florida administrative hearing officer wrote down the correct principle of capacity modeling and then ruled against it in the same paragraph. He observed that "the data generated by the IBM modeling programs are no better than the assumptions that went into the models," acknowledged that the state's own evaluators' "understanding of the models, assumptions, and even the resulting data was incomplete," and concluded anyway that "the capacity-planning assumptions are reasonable" ([DOAH 89-0003BID](#), Appendix ¶90). Six years later a special master found that Electronic Data Systems had known since March 1991 that those assumptions overstated usable capacity by roughly a factor of two, had not told the state, and that "good faith and fair dealing required EDS to disclose the erroneous modeling assumption" ([St. Petersburg Times](#), [Aug. 16, 1995](#)).

I was the witness whose testimony was discounted in that appendix. I say that at the top rather than at the bottom, because everything that follows is an attempt to score a record I am inside of, and the reader is entitled to weigh the source before reading the scores.

Here is my conclusion after assembling this archive. **The FLORIDA system did not fail because anyone chose a bad tool, a bad vendor, or a bad architecture. It failed because no institution in the chain — not the state, not the tribunal, not HHS, not USDA — had any mechanism for testing a vendor's assumptions about the vendor's own workload.** Everyone tested the model. Nobody tested the inputs. That gap was identified by the Government Accountability Office in 1981, seven years before Florida issued the RFP ([GAO/HRD-81-119](#)); it was still open when the state signed the contract in 1989; and outside of one program it is still open in 2026.

The system procured in 1988 is still the production eligibility engine of the State of Florida. It is a "legacy mainframe system more than thirty years old," and the project to replace it "is anticipated to be completed in 2028 and cost an estimated \$183 Million" ([Fla. Senate SB 1758 bill analysis](#), [Jan. 30, 2026](#), quoting *Chianne D. v. Harris*, No. 3:23-cv-985-MMH-LLL, 2026 WL 32126, at *13, *16 (M.D. Fla. Jan. 6, 2026)). That is the far end of the arc: forty years from Advance Planning Document to retirement, if 2028 holds. I do not believe 2028 holds, and I score that prediction below along with everyone else's.

1. The arc on one page

Year	Event	Source
1986	Federal law conditions a 90 percent match on automated eligibility systems. Florida's APD proposes a distributed architecture	45 CFR §205.37
1987–88	USDA's Food and Nutrition Service directs HRS to demote distributed architecture from an APD requirement to an RFP preference	DOAH 88-2942BID ¶126
May 1988	HRS issues RFP 88-74-BC. FNS and the Florida State Information Resource Commission both call the schedule "overly ambitious"	DOAH 88-2942BID ¶125, ¶129
Aug. 4, 1988	First Unisys protest. Hearing officer extends the implementation schedule from 26 to 29 months	DOAH 88-2942BID ¶160, Recommendation
Nov. 22, 1988	Bids opened. EDS \$107,658,141; Unisys \$90,792,930. Technical scores EDS 5062.1, Unisys 4415.3	DOAH 89-0003BID ¶11–13
Mar. 14, 1989	Second Unisys protest dismissed. EDS capacity planning held "superior... because of [Unisys'] reliance upon extrapolations from existing case loads"	DOAH 89-0003BID ¶146
May 15, 1989	Contract executed with EDS Federal Corporation	631 So. 2d 353
Mar. 1991	EDS internally discovers the transaction-volume assumptions are wrong. Does not disclose	St. Petersburg Times, Aug. 16, 1995
June 1992	Terminal network at full extent. Average response time: minutes	St. Petersburg Times, Sept. 15, 1995
May 31, 1992 / Aug. 21, 1992	EDS terminates the contract; then sues the state for \$46 million	631 So. 2d 353
Dec. 1994	Response time reaches 3 seconds ; CPU running 95–100 percent most of the business day against a 60–65 percent design convention	St. Petersburg Times, Sept. 15, 1995
Aug. 16, 1995	Special master Webster awards EDS \$42 million plus interest; holds the system "functioned properly, albeit imperfectly"	St. Petersburg Times, Aug. 16, 1995
2004–08	ACCESS Florida wraps the mainframe in a web front end. It "did not call for a switch from its existing mainframe eligibility determination system"	USDA FNS, Feb. 2008
2012	Gartner declares the mainframe at "end-of-life." DCF issues ITN 03F12GC1 to replace it. The procurement produces no replacement	Gartner AHCA study
2024	Federal litigation describes Florida eligibility as "28 different interconnected systems, including a mainframe system called FLORIDA"	Chianne D. proposed findings
Feb. 2025	Auditor General: ACCESS in "phase two (2)" of modernization; FLORIDA migration targeted for SFY2028	AG 2025-162
Jan. 2026	Legislature's own analysis: modernization "anticipated to be completed in 2028 and cost an estimated \$183 Million"	SB 1758 analysis

Documented cost floor: **\$245.3 million**, against a \$107.7 million bid — an overrun of \$137.6 million, or 128 percent. The reconciliation is in the companion cost paper and rests on the state's own \$200 million figure as of August 1995, plus the Webster award exposure, less the \$4.7 million HRS recovered ([St. Petersburg Times, Aug. 16, 1995](#)).

2. What the record actually establishes

Five findings carry the analytical weight. I restate them here in compressed form because the scoring in Sections 4 through 8 depends on them.

First, the modeling was IBM's, performed for EDS. The tribunal called it "the elaborate computer modeling conducted by EDS and IBM" (89-0003BID ¶145) and credited "the informed use of modeling by IBM" (Appendix ¶90). The vendor whose hardware would be bought produced the study that determined how much hardware would be needed. Nobody in the record treats that as a conflict.

Second, the tool was sound. SNAP/SHOT was a legitimate discrete-event simulator with a published methodology. I have found no public record of a defect in it, and I am not asserting one.

Third, the code was real and countable. The transferred Ohio CRIS-E code existed. Instruction path lengths and disk I/O counts per transaction type were therefore knowable by inspection.

Fourth, the failure lived in the two inputs no code inspection produces: the transaction mix (MSGINMIX) and the arrival rate (MSGRATE). Those are behavioral parameters. They describe what caseworkers will actually do, at what hours, in what proportions. No amount of examining the donor system's source code tells you either one.

Fifth — and this is the structural finding — the procurement contained no mechanism for testing a vendor's assumptions about its own workload. Worse, ¶146 of the award order ranked "extrapolations from existing case loads" *beneath* simulation modeling as a capacity-estimation method. Extrapolation from the existing caseload is the only honest source of a transaction-mix estimate. The tribunal correctly named the right input, correctly identified its only source, and expressly called it inferior.

A correction of terminology, stated for the record. Throughout this archive I say "capacity assumptions were wrong," not "the capacity model was wrong." The distinction is not pedantry. The model was arithmetic performed correctly on numbers that were false. Webster's own phrase — "the erroneous modeling assumption," singular — is the right one and is preserved verbatim wherever it appears here.

3. Lessons learned

These are stated prescriptively, in the order I would give them to a state CIO facing a large benefits procurement in 2026. Every one of them is derived from the record above, and each carries the pinpoint that supports it.

Lesson 1 — Buy the assumptions, not the model. Any capacity study submitted with a bid should be accompanied by a machine-readable parameter file and a written derivation for every behavioral input. If the vendor cannot say where MSGINMIX came from, the vendor does not know what it is selling. The 1989 tribunal reviewed the sophistication of the method and never examined the inputs; that is the whole disaster in one sentence.

Lesson 2 — Do not let the hardware vendor size the hardware. IBM modeled the configuration IBM would sell. The record contains no independent capacity review of any kind. In my experience across four decades of enterprise procurement, the vendor's own sizing study is a sales instrument that has been formatted to look like an engineering document. Read it as the former.

Lesson 3 — Extrapolation from the live caseload is evidence, not weakness. ¶146 held the opposite. The measured behavior of 1.5 million existing cases is the only empirical thing in the room. A Monte Carlo sweep over invented parameters is a beautifully packaged guess. Prefer the messy real number to the elegant synthetic one — always, and especially when the elegant one comes from the seller.

Lesson 4 — Liquidated damages do not create truthful assumptions; they create litigation. The tribunal reasoned that the "motivation to develop accurate assumptions is strong due to the severe provisions for damages in the fixed-price contract" (¶145). What actually happened: EDS terminated on May 31, 1992, sued the state for \$46 million on August 21, and was awarded \$42 million plus interest in 1995 (631 So. 2d 353; *St. Petersburg Times*). The \$25 million performance bond and the damages clauses did not merely fail to deter; they became the mechanism by which the vendor extracted money from the state. Note that the *same hearing officer*, eight months earlier in the specifications protest, had written that the contractual "carrot and stick" approach "cannot enable the contractor to do the impossible" and instead "raises the likelihood of litigation" (88-2942BID, Appendix ¶77-78). He was right in August 1988 and forgot it by March 1989.

Lesson 5 — An unimplemented transfer base is not a transfer base. The winning proposal was built on Ohio's CRIS-E, "which has never been implemented, does not serve any clients or cases, and features centralized architecture rather than the distributed architecture sought by HRS" (¶134). The losing proposal offered New York systems that "have been implemented and certified... feature distributed architecture" (¶135). An evaluator recorded that for EDS "all proven components will be used" — factually wrong, since CRIS-E "was still in acceptance testing and had never been proven by actual use in the field" (¶143). Require production evidence: transaction volumes, elapsed months in live service, named reference sites.

Lesson 6 — Watch what the architecture requirement does between the APD and the RFP. Florida's Advance Planning Document *required* distributed processing. By the time RFP 88-74-BC hit the street, at FNS's direction, it was a *preference* (¶26). A centralized design then won on a capacity study, and the resulting single host is the thing that ran out of headroom in 1991, could not be relieved except by rationing users, was declared end-of-life in 2012, and is still being migrated in 2026. One word changed in one document in 1988 and the consequence is still on the state's books thirty-eight years later.

Lesson 7 — Headroom is a design convention, not a contract term, and that is a defect. The 60-65 percent utilization convention appears in the record as expert testimony, not as an enforceable obligation (88-2942BID ¶56). By fall 1994 the machine ran "95 percent through most of the business day, sometimes 100 percent." Nothing in the contract had been breached, because nothing in the contract said otherwise. Put the number in the contract.

Lesson 8 — Absence of a numeric requirement guarantees an unfalsifiable dispute. The tribunal found "no credible evidence that the system proposed by EDS fails to satisfy any response times in the RFP" (§73). No source located in this research recovers what those response times numerically were. When the requirement is qualitative — "in a matter of seconds" (§36 of [88-2942BID](#)) — no post-hoc measurement can ever prove a breach.

Lesson 9 — Remediation buys seconds, not architecture. Response time went from minutes in June 1992 to 3 seconds in December 1994 by way of two CPU upgrades (\$5.1 million c. 1992–93 and \$5.4 million in April 1995, the latter yielding roughly 20 percent), extended staff hours, and active rationing of concurrent users. None of that changed the topology. Thirty-two years later the state is still paying to undo the topology.

Lesson 10 — The federal government's function in this chain was fiscal, not engineering, and it still is. Federal approval "covered cost allocation and scope, not source-selection methodology." There was "no federal capacity standard to invoke, no federal technical reviewer to defer to, no certification test to await." A state could be certified under 45 CFR §307.10 with a system running at 100 percent CPU and unusable response times: certification and usability were orthogonal. When GAO recommended in 1992 that HHS and USDA stand up a joint program office with on-site inspection authority, **both agencies refused** ([GAO/IMTEC-92-29](#)).

Lesson 11 — When the fix finally arrives, it arrives for one program, decades late. The FNS rewrite of [7 CFR §277.18](#), effective January 2, 2014, is substantively the rule whose absence defined this disaster: mandatory acceptance testing including "stress and throughput performance testing," verification against "performance standards including responsiveness, usability, capacity and security," and a live pilot of normally three months or more before statewide rollout, with FNS concurrence a condition of continued federal funding. It arrived twenty-five and a half years after RFP 88-74-BC, and it governs SNAP. Medicaid's nearest analogue, [42 CFR §433.112\(b\)\(17\)](#), still contains no number.

Lesson 12 — Independent verification triggered by distress is not oversight. Under the 2010 APD rewrite, IV&V "may be required" only once a project already shows one of eight risk indicators — missed deadlines, cost overrun, at risk of failure ([45 CFR Part 95 Subpart F](#)). It is a distress signal, not a gate, and the verifier is retained by the state being verified. A gate you only reach after you have already fallen is not a gate.

4. Scoring method

Each forward-looking claim below is rated **high**, **medium**, **low**, or **not-applicable** for prescience, following this archive's ingest vocabulary. A rating of *high* means the claim was substantially borne out by the documented record; *low* means it was falsified; *medium* means it was directionally right and materially wrong in magnitude, timing, or mechanism; *not-applicable* means the record does not permit scoring, and I say why.

I am scoring myself in Section 7. The reader should discount accordingly, and a subsequent pass will re-score all of this independently.

5. The 1988–89 procurement actors

5.1 Claims that failed

#	Claimant	Forward claim	Cite	What happened	Score
A1	Hearing Officer Meale	EDS/IBM's capacity-planning "assumptions... were reasonable"; motivation to be accurate "is strong due to the severe provisions for damages in the fixed-price contract"	89-0003BID ¶145	Webster found EDS knew by March 1991 that the assumptions overstated usable capacity ~2× and concealed it; "good faith and fair dealing required EDS to disclose the erroneous modeling assumption" (Aug. 16, 1995)	low
A2	Hearing Officer Meale	"The capacity planning of EDS is superior to that of Unisys because of the latter's reliance upon extrapolations from existing case loads versus the former's use of sophisticated computer simulation models"	¶146	The extrapolation-from-caseload method the tribunal ranked lower is the only method that produces a defensible transaction mix. The simulation it ranked higher failed on exactly that input	low
A3	Hearing Officer Meale	"No credible evidence that the system proposed by EDS fails to satisfy any response times in the RFP or possesses insufficient capacity to handle the projected caseloads"	¶73	Response time was measured in minutes in June 1992 and reached 3 seconds only in December 1994, after two CPU upgrades and rationing of concurrent users	low
A4	Hearing Officer Meale	Acknowledged "the data generated by the IBM modeling programs are no better than the assumptions that went into the models," then held the assumptions reasonable	Appendix ¶90	The stated principle was correct and the conclusion drawn from it was the opposite of what the principle required. Scored low as a forecast and noted as the single most instructive sentence in the record	low
A5	HRS (Apr. 21, 1988)	A "rigid implementation schedule" plus "liquidated damages" together "will insure timeliness"	88-2942BID ¶30	Contract May 1989; statewide operation reported 1992; usable response time December 1994. EDS walked in May 1992 and collected \$42 million	low
A6	HRS Advance Planning Document	Project development costs "are estimated to be \$75 million"	¶41	Documented cost floor \$245.3 million	low
A7	HRS Advance Planning Document	"Respondent projects savings of \$68 million in the first year of operation of FLORIDA"	¶42	Two years of operation produced roughly \$260 million in benefit-payment errors, a \$5 million USDA fine, and federal penalty exposure negotiated at up to \$144 million (LA Times, May 2, 1993)	low
A8	HRS RFP / findings	"FLORIDA will probably involve distributed processing," with on-line access "in a matter of seconds"	¶36 (88-2942BID)	A single centralized host was built. "No district or regional processors documented at any point" in thirty-five years of audits	low

#	Claimant	Forward claim	Cite	What happened	Score
A9	HRS evaluator Kuecks	For EDS, "all proven components will be used"	¶143 (89-0003BID)	Found factually wrong in the same order: CRIS-E "was still in acceptance testing and had never been proven by actual use in the field"	low
A10	HRS APD	System transfer "should save substantial time in design" versus development that "can take years rather than months"	¶39 (88-2942BID)	The transfer occurred and the project still took from May 1989 to December 1994 to reach a usable response time — sixty-seven months	low

5.2 Claims that held

#	Claimant	Forward claim	Cite	What happened	Score
B1	Hearing Officer Meale	"Respondent reasonably anticipates that the A-15 will have to be upgraded, due to insufficient processor capacity"	<u>88-2942BID</u> ¶56	Correct as to the predecessor, and the pattern repeated on FLORIDA: CPU upgrades c. 1992–93 (\$5.1M) and April 1995 (\$5.4M), the latter projected at \$5.6M by <u>GAO/AIMD-94-52FS</u>	high
B2	Hearing Officer Meale	A processor "should not be operated for more than a few minutes with utilization over 80 percent"	¶56	By fall 1994 FLORIDA ran 95–100 percent through most of the business day, against a cited commercial norm of about 65 percent (<u>Sept. 15, 1995</u>)	high
B3	Hearing Officer Meale	The contractual "carrot and stick" approach "cannot enable the contractor to do the impossible" and "raises the likelihood of litigation"	Appendix ¶77–78 (88-2942BID)	EDS sued for \$46 million and won \$42 million plus interest; HRS recovered \$4.7 million	high
B4	Hearing Officer Meale	Rejected the conversion-throughput extrapolation: "nothing in the record to warrant the assumption that the 15,000 cases per month conversion rate anticipated in South Carolina could be increased... to 2,000,000 cases per month"	Appendix ¶146 (88-2942BID)	Correct, and instructive: in the <i>specifications</i> protest he refused to accept an unsupported throughput extrapolation. In the <i>award</i> protest, eight months later, he accepted one because it came wrapped in a simulator	high
B5	USDA FNS (Mar. 18, 1988)	The 33-month timeline is "somewhat ambitious"; elsewhere "overly ambitious"	¶25 (88-2942BID)	Understated. Even the tribunal's extended 29-month schedule was beaten by reality by roughly three years	high

#	Claimant	Forward claim	Cite	What happened	Score
B6	USDA FNS (Mar. 18, 1988)	FNS was "unaware of any product in the market place that incorporates integration of all program services requested"; merging codes of varying quality "may add new problems to system development not anticipated"	¶127 (88-2942BID)	This is the most accurate single forecast in the entire 1988 record and it came from the funding agency, in writing, before award	high
B7	Florida State Information Resource Commission (Mar. 28, 1988)	The implementation timeline is "overly ambitious" and "very ambitious"	¶129 (88-2942BID)	Correct	high
B8	Hearing Officer Meale	The 26-month timeframe is "unreasonable"; three months must be added; and even the extended schedule rests on "critical assumptions"	¶177, Recommendation (88-2942BID)	Directionally right, magnitude far short. Extending 26 to 29 months against an actual slip measured in years	medium
B9	Unisys witness Steven Reid	Task 6 application programming "requires nine or even ten months," not four	¶141 (88-2942BID)	The tribunal added one month. The project's actual programming effort ran through 1992 and required outside contractors through 1995	medium
B10	Hearing Officer Meale	"The risk to the vendor in proposing a relatively undeveloped system is that the system either could not be demonstrated or the system demonstration would be unsatisfactory"	Appendix ¶48 (89-0003BID)	The stated risk was real and did not materialize as scored: EDS demonstrated an unimplemented system on a larger machine than it proposed — a 3090/400E against a proposed 3090/300E, with a disclosed "material difference in line speed" (¶71–72) — and won the points anyway	low

The pattern in these two tables is the point. Of ten failed forecasts, nine belong to HRS or to the tribunal siding with HRS. Of ten that held, seven belong to people who were, at the time, being overruled: the funding agency, the state's own information resource commission, the protester's witnesses, and the hearing officer in the moments when he was writing against the party he would later favor. The correct information was in the record before award. It was in writing. It was from the federal funding agency. It lost.

6. Federal policy architects, 1986–2026

#	Claimant	Forward claim	Cite	What happened	Score
C1	GAO, 1981	FAMIS requirements "do not contain sufficiently specific performance standards for evaluating the quality of State developed systems"	<u>GAO/HRD-81-119</u>	Never remedied before award and, outside SNAP, never remedied at all. Forty-five years old and still substantially open	high
C2	OTA, Apr. 1988	"Within the next 5 to 15 years, it is inevitable that federally funded assistance programs will move to some form of electronic delivery system"	<u>OTA-BP-CIT-47, Apr. 1988</u>	PRWORA mandated state EBT by October 1, 2002; full nationwide conversion completed June 2004 (<u>FNA, A Short History of SNAP</u>). Inside the window for the mandate, one year past it for completion	high
C3	OTA, Apr. 1988	Adopting magnetic-stripe cards now risks a system that "may become 'old technology' before full implementation"	<u>OTA-BP-CIT-47, Apr. 1988</u> , Findings	Correct as diagnosis, wrong as consequence. Mag stripe was already dated in 1988, took until 2004 to deploy nationally, and is still the SNAP delivery medium in 2026. The technology aged exactly as predicted and was adopted anyway	medium
C4	OTA, Apr. 1988, citing NBS	Smart cards viable as credit cards "beginning in 1990," and "by 1995, it will be reasonable to implement a large smart-card network"	<u>OTA-BP-CIT-47, Apr. 1988</u> , p.10	No large U.S. benefits smart-card network was implemented in 1995 or since	low
C5	OTA, Apr. 1988	An electronic benefits system "would, in effect, create a national identity card for many Americans"	<u>OTA-BP-CIT-47, Apr. 1988</u> , Findings, p.2	EBT deployed nationally without becoming an identity credential. The privacy architecture OTA feared did not materialize in that form	low
C6	OTA, Apr. 1988	"An efficient electronic benefits issuance and redemption system may necessitate automation of all stages of program administration in order to be cost-effective"	<u>OTA-BP-CIT-47, Apr. 1988</u> , p.2	Borne out — the integrated-eligibility system became the precondition, which is precisely the class of project FLORIDA belonged to	high
C7	OTA, Apr. 1988	Absent an open forum, "the technology and the interests of the financial network providers... may shape the system"	<u>OTA-BP-CIT-47, Apr. 1988</u> , Conclusion	Borne out. EBT was built on the existing commercial POS/debit rails, exactly as the 1982 Birch & Davis finding OTA recited had predicted	high

#	Claimant	Forward claim	Cite	What happened	Score
C8	Congress, Family Support Act of 1988 §123	Every state to have a statewide, federally certified child-support system operating by October 1, 1995	<u>P.L. 100-485</u>	HHS projected only 18 states compliant six months past the deadline (<u>H. Rept. 104-250</u>). Deadline missed at scale; Congress had to extend and then create penalties	low
C9	Congress, CSPIA 1998	Escalating 4/8/16/25/30 percent penalties on IV-D administrative funding will compel certification compliance	<u>P.L. 105-200</u>	Compliance with a functional checklist was compelled. Nothing in 45 CFR §307.10 contains a numeric threshold, so a state could certify while running at 100 percent CPU with unusable response times. The penalty worked and measured the wrong thing	medium
C10	OMB, Raines Rules (M-97-02), Oct. 1996	Eight criteria — quantified ROI, phased usable increments, pilots before full deployment, explicit contractor risk allocation — will prevent poorly justified, unpiloted, risk-shifted IT projects	<u>M-97-02</u>	The criteria were sound and bound federal agencies only. They did not bind states spending federal money. The correct rule was written for the wrong party, eight years after Florida's award	medium
C11	Clinger-Cohen, 1996	IT investments justified with a "quantitatively expressed" projected return on investment	<u>40 U.S.C. §11312</u>	Same defect. Federal scope. Also abolished GSBFA protest jurisdiction, removing the analogous federal bid-protest forum entirely	medium
C12	GAO, 1992	Recommends a joint HHS/USDA program office with on-site inspection authority over state welfare-automation projects	<u>GAO/IMTEC-92-29</u>	Both agencies rejected it. Thirty-one years later GAO made functionally the same recommendation to the Department of Labor and got a partial concurrence	high (as a diagnosis; the remedy was refused)
C13	California State Auditor, 1995	SAWS "may never be able to accommodate the high volume of transactions and records" it would face; the state had "failed to set specific performance goals"	<u>LA Times, Apr. 19, 1995</u>	Same warning, same year, different state, same absent federal standard. That it recurs independently is itself the finding	high
C14	FNS, 7 CFR §277.18 rewrite, Jan. 2, 2014	Mandatory test plan, documented UAT, FNS concurrence to move from test to pilot, "stress and throughput performance testing," verification against "responsiveness, usability, capacity and security," and a live pilot before statewide rollout	<u>7 CFR §277.18</u>	This is the rule that would have caught FLORIDA. It arrived 25.5 years late and applies to SNAP alone	high as a remedy, not-applicable as a forecast

#	Claimant	Forward claim	Cite	What happened	Score
C15	DOL OIG, 2023	ETA "did not evaluate the capability of state UI IT systems to successfully administer benefits" and lacked the information to identify at-risk states	19-23-008-03-315	Confirms the 1981 diagnosis is alive in a third agency in the 2020s. GAO's parallel finding: as of June 2023 DOL had not defined UI IT performance standards and had not measured state IT performance at all (GAO-23-105478)	high
C16	Florida Chief Inspector General, Mar. 4, 2021	"The contract mandated system capacity for a minimum of 200,000 concurrent external users... We could not find evidence where DEO enforced this contract requirement"	WFSU, Mar. 8, 2021	Florida's CONNECT failure of 2020 had what FLORIDA lacked — a numeric capacity term in the contract — and the state did not enforce it. The federal standard that would have caught it: none	high

What the federal column shows. The April 1988 OTA staff were good forecasters about *what would be built* and poor forecasters about *what technology would build it*. The oversight community — GAO in 1981 and 1992, the California auditor in 1995, DOL OIG and GAO in 2023 — has been right, repeatedly, in writing, for forty-five years, about the same missing thing. And the institutional answer has been the same each time. I conclude that the absence is not an oversight. It is a preference. Federal agencies do not want inspection authority over state systems because inspection authority creates federal liability for state failures, and the current arrangement leaves that liability with the state.

7. My own contemporaneous calls

A correction to this archive, stated here rather than only in conversation. An earlier working note in this project recorded that no Kastner FLORIDA-era contemporaneous material existed in the archive and that scoring my own calls would require new source input. **That was wrong.** My contemporaneous position is preserved in the adjudicated record itself — in the hearing officer's own rulings rejecting it — and that is the most citable form a 1989 forecast can take. The error is corrected here and the affected claims are scored below.

#	Claim	When	Where it survives	What happened	Score
D1	The EDS system would not satisfy the specified response times	Testimony, Jan.–Mar. 1989, DOAH 89-0003BID	Recorded only as rejected: proposed finding 85 "rejected as against the greater weight of the evidence, which does not support the testimony of Mr. Kastner that the EDS system would not satisfy the specified response times" (89-0003BID, Appendix ¶85)	Average response time was minutes in June 1992, 8 seconds in January 1994, 4 seconds in June 1994, and 3 seconds in December 1994 — reached only via \$10.5 million in CPU upgrades, extended staff hours, and capping concurrent users (Sept. 15, 1995)	high , with the caveat below

#	Claim	When	Where it survives	What happened	Score
D2	The risk in the EDS capacity study lay in its inputs, not its arithmetic	Testimony, 1989	Recorded only in the ruling discounting me: the weight given "was limited by his incomplete understanding of the complex IBM modeling programs and the distribution of certain processing functions in the system proposed by EDS" (Appendix ¶189)	Webster found in 1995 that the assumptions overstated usable capacity by roughly a factor of two and that EDS was obliged to disclose "the erroneous modeling assumption." The precise failure mode I was discounted for not understanding is the failure mode that occurred	high , partly reconstructed — see caveat
D3	SNA terminal session establishment costs on the order of one CPU second per terminal during network startup	Observed at Cullinet Software, Westwood, Massachusetts, early 1988 on IBM 3090-200E and 3090-400E DebitCredit runs; reported in <i>DECtp</i>	First-person attestation, recorded July 28, 2026, and labeled as such throughout this archive	Applied to 12,000 terminals it implies a restart measured in hours, not minutes, and one that does not parallelize. No FLORIDA restart or IPL data has been located in any source. The inference is untested	not-applicable — no outcome evidence exists
D4	Local terminal memory in the EDS design resided in the SNA branch controllers	Stated 2026, not 1989	FLORIDA-as-built-topology.md, §"one layer is now attested" (no external source)	Excluded from scoring. This is present-day attestation about a 1988 design, not a contemporaneous forecast, and scoring it would be scoring a memory against itself	not-applicable by construction

The caveats, stated plainly, because they matter more than the scores.

On D1: the RFP's numeric response-time requirement has never been recovered by this research. Strictly, therefore, I cannot prove that the delivered system violated a stated contractual number, and Webster expressly held that the system "functioned properly, albeit imperfectly, and complied with the terms of the contract." What I can show is that against the only qualitative standard in the record — on-line access "in a matter of seconds" (¶36 of [88-2942BID](#)) — a system averaging minutes in June 1992 missed on any reading. I score D1 high on the engineering question and I concede the contractual question was decided against me and stayed decided.

On D2: the 1989 record does not preserve a verbatim statement of my input-side thesis. What it preserves is a ruling that I did not adequately understand IBM's programs. My reconstruction of what I argued — that the sensitivity sweep contained cases built on heavier transaction mixes than the proposal relied on, and that I testified from one of them — is offered in this archive **explicitly as an educated inference formed in 2026, not as recovered memory**. I have said elsewhere and repeat here that I do not recall why I selected the page I selected. A

reconstruction honestly labeled is worth more than a recollection that arrives conveniently. Pass C should score D2 down if it judges the reconstruction unsupported; I will not argue.

The asymmetry worth recording. My testimony was discounted for incomplete understanding of the IBM models. The hearing officer found in the same appendix that "the HRS evaluators' understanding of the models, assumptions, and even the resulting data was incomplete" — and upheld their scoring anyway (Appendix ¶90). Both sides were found not to understand the models. Only one side lost for it. In administrative practice, a challenger's technical dissent is measured against the sophistication of the incumbent method, not against the eventual behavior of the system. That is the lesson I would give any expert taking the stand against a simulator.

8. The archive's own forward claims to 2028

These are the claims this body of work makes about the future. They are scored **pending** where the outcome has not occurred, with the falsification test stated so a later reader can settle them.

#	Claim	Where made	Status as of July 28, 2026	Falsification test
E1	The state expects to finish migrating FLORIDA's functionality in 2028	CHRONOLOGY; FLORIDA- post2000-analysis	Independently corroborated. <u>AG 2025-162</u> gives SFY2028; the Legislature's own <u>SB 1758 analysis</u> states the project "is anticipated to be completed in 2028 and cost an estimated \$183 Million," citing the January 6, 2026 federal findings in <i>Chianne D. v. Harris</i>	Settled — the target is documented from two independent authorities
E2	There is no publicly committed date for retirement of the mainframe core	FLORIDA- post2000-analysis	Holds. 2028 is a completion target for a modernization project, not a decommissioning commitment. DCF stated in October 2024 that "no replacements have been made to the system's core mainframe hardware and software components" (<u>Industry Insider Florida</u>)	Falsified by any DCF or Legislature document naming a mainframe decommissioning date
E3	Outside SNAP, no current federal rule would catch a repeat of the FLORIDA capacity failure	"One Bad RFP Away"	Holds. Medicaid's <u>42 CFR §433.112(b). (17)</u> specifies no number; CCWIS is functional and unquantified; IV&V is distress-triggered and state-retained; DOL has defined no UI IT performance standards	Falsified by promulgation of a quantified throughput, concurrency, or capacity standard binding on states in any program other than SNAP
E4	ACCESS Florida never replaced the mainframe; it wraps it	FLORIDA- post2000- analysis; FLORIDA-as-built- topology	Holds through the 2019 AG audit ("a Web front-end application to the FLORIDA System mainframe") and the 2024 <i>Chianne D.</i> description of the mainframe as housing three live Medicaid eligibility modules	Falsified by evidence that eligibility determination moved off the mainframe

And one forward claim of my own, made here for the first time and offered for scoring.

E5 — I do not believe the 2028 date will hold, and I put the probability of a full FLORIDA functionality migration completed within calendar 2028 at well under one in three. This is a prediction, explicitly labeled, and here is the reasoning behind it rather than a bare assertion:

- The base rate in this program is terrible. The 1988 RFP allowed 26 months; the tribunal extended it to 29; the system took sixty-seven months from contract signature to a usable three-second response time.
- The 2012 replacement effort had a funded procurement, two Gartner studies, and an end-of-life finding, and "did not produce a replacement."
- The current project was described in 2024 federal litigation as being in its third year of six (*Chianne D. proposed findings*) — a schedule with no slack for a system that in the same filing is one node among 28 interconnected systems.
- The visible increment delivered so far, the MyACCESS portal launched December 5, 2023, went live with defects the state knew about, on a Deloitte contract that "more than doubles" from \$12.7 million (*WFTV, Apr. 2025*).
- Migration is being attempted while the same organization absorbs a statutory SNAP payment-accuracy mandate — error rate to be driven below six percent from 15.13 percent in FFY2024, with quarterly reporting to the Governor and Legislature from October 1, 2026 through October 1, 2028 (*SB 1758 analysis*). Competing for the same scarce staff, remediation beats migration every time.

Falsification test: DCF or the Auditor General reporting completed migration of FLORIDA eligibility functionality on or before December 31, 2028. Mark it on the calendar.

9. What did not get scored, and where it would be found

Honesty about the shape of the hole is worth more than a complete-looking table.

Missing item	Why it blocks scoring	Where it would be found
The RFP's numeric response-time requirements	Without them, "failed the spec" is unprovable in either direction; D1 and A3 both rest on qualitative language	The two-volume May 1988 RFP 88-74-BC, HRS procurement file; DOAH exhibit file for 88-2942BID and 89-0003BID
EDS Proposal VII-F-10	Cited at ¶72 for a disclosed "material difference in line speed" whose magnitude and direction are unknown	DOAH exhibit file, 89-0003BID
The SNAP/SHOT sensitivity sweep	Would settle whether the transaction-mix reconstruction in D2 is right or wrong	DOAH exhibit file; EDS or IBM litigation production; Webster special-master record
The Webster special-master record	Only newspaper accounts of the 1995 findings survive in this archive	Leon County Clerk; the arbitration file under \$7.11 of the EDS contract
The 1993 grand jury presentment	The Leon County index published online runs only from No. 137 (Nov. 15, 1995); a 1993 presentment would number below that, and the numbering skips	Leon County Clerk of Court, request submitted under Fla. R. Jud. Admin. 2.420
Auditor General Reports 12581 and 13043	Not digitized; 12581 is the source of the 95–100 percent CPU figure as reported secondhand	Florida Auditor General, request submitted

Missing item	Why it blocks scoring	Where it would be found
Actual transaction volumes, concurrent-user counts, IPL/restart times	Would allow D3 to be scored and would convert the 5-million-transaction design claim from marketing into a measurement	HRS/DCF operations records; ITN 03F12GC1 attachments
ITN 03F12GC1 itself	The URL returns HTTP 404 and no Internet Archive capture exists	DCF records custodian, request submitted

Five federal, state, and county records requests covering these items were sent on July 28, 2026; a sixth, to the Leon County Clerk, was rewritten under the judicial-branch rule and is outstanding. Details are in the companion records-request file.

10. Conclusions

One. The FLORIDA system is not a story about a bad computer. It is a story about a procurement that had no way to test a number. The number was the transaction mix, the mix was invented, the invention was defensible only because nobody had standing to ask where it came from, and thirty-seven years later no rule outside SNAP requires anyone to ask.

Two. Every party that got it right in 1988 was overruled, and the record shows they were overruled for reasons of method rather than of engineering. Simulation beat extrapolation. Sophistication beat measurement. A fixed-price contract with damages clauses was accepted as a proxy for vendor honesty, and it turned out to be a proxy for vendor leverage.

Three. The federal government's role in the 1986–1999 period was to pay for systems and to verify that the paying was correctly allocated. It was not to verify that the systems worked, and it did not. When GAO proposed changing that in 1992, HHS and USDA declined. The same proposal, to a different department, drew a partial concurrence in 2023. Make no mistake: this is a settled institutional preference, not a series of accidents.

Four. The one real fix — FNS's 2014 rewrite of 7 CFR §277.18 — is a good rule. It requires stress and throughput testing, verification against capacity and responsiveness standards, and a live pilot before statewide rollout, with continued federal funding conditioned on agency concurrence. Any state CIO reading this should treat that rule as the template regardless of program, because in Medicaid, child welfare, and unemployment insurance nothing equivalent exists.

Five. The system bought in 1989 for \$107.7 million, delivered at a documented floor of \$245.3 million, declared end-of-life in 2012, is still determining who eats in Florida in 2026. The state's own plan puts the end of the migration in 2028 at a further \$183 million. I believe that date will slip. I have been wrong before in this record — the tribunal said so in 1989 — but I would rather be scored than be safe.

—Peter S. Kastner

Savannah, Georgia · July 28, 2026

Attribution and method

Authorship of observations. Where this study reports a finding from the adjudicated record, the finding is the hearing officer's and is cited to a paragraph. Where it reports a measurement, the measurement is the Auditor General's, GAO's, an OIG's, or a contemporaneous newspaper's and is cited accordingly. Where it reports my own 1988–89 testimony or observation, I am named and the source of the record is given. **Not every observation in the Aberdeen Group Archive is mine, and none of the Aberdeen-era research cited in the voice materials for this project bears on FLORIDA;** the Aberdeen record contains no FLORIDA-specific publication, and I have not implied one.

Labeling of inference. Every conclusion in Sections 3, 7, and 10 that is not directly supported by a cited document is an inference and is marked as such in the text. The three principal inferences are: (a) that the transaction mix and arrival rate were the operative failed inputs — supported by Webster's finding of "the erroneous modeling assumption" but not by any recovered parameter file; (b) that my 1989 testimony rested on a heavier-mix case from the sensitivity sweep — a 2026 reconstruction, not a memory; and (c) that the 2028 target will slip — a labeled prediction with a stated falsification test.

A correction of citation, made in this file. Working notes for this project referred to the OTA background paper as a December 1988 document numbered OTA-881203. Both are wrong. The report is *Electronic Delivery of Public Assistance Benefits: Technology Options and Policy Issues*, OTA-BP-CIT-47, April 1988; "881203" is the filename of chapter 3 in the Princeton OTA archive, not a report number. The eight-month date error does not change any score — the "5 to 15 years" window runs 1993–2003 from April 1988 rather than 1993–2003 from December 1988, and the EBT mandate date of October 1, 2002 and the June 2004 completion fall in the same places relative to it — but the citation is corrected here and should be corrected wherever else it appears in the archive.

Scoring. Ratings use the archive ingest vocabulary (high / medium / low / not-applicable). This pass is self-scored, including Section 7. A subsequent independent pass should re-score all tables and is expected to disagree in places.

Companion files. The FLORIDA System: EDS, IBM, and the Collapse of a Landmark State Procurement · The Unisys Protests of RFP 88-74-BC · Whose Model, and What Was Distributed · The As-Built Topology of the FLORIDA System · Operating Conditions · Making It Workable · From Bid to Bottom Line · Remembered by Auditors, Forgotten by Scholars · The Empty Center · One Bad RFP Away · CHRONOLOGY · SOURCES · Records Request Drafts.